

Designing AI Managers Could Trust

T.L.D.R.

Redesigned VML's peer feedback tool so employees always knew where they stood, and turned an AI summary concept into a human-assisted interface managers trusted.

- Won 3 Awards
- Lauded by C-Suite Leadership

Role

Sole product and visual designer reporting to the Global Director of Talent and Org Effectiveness.

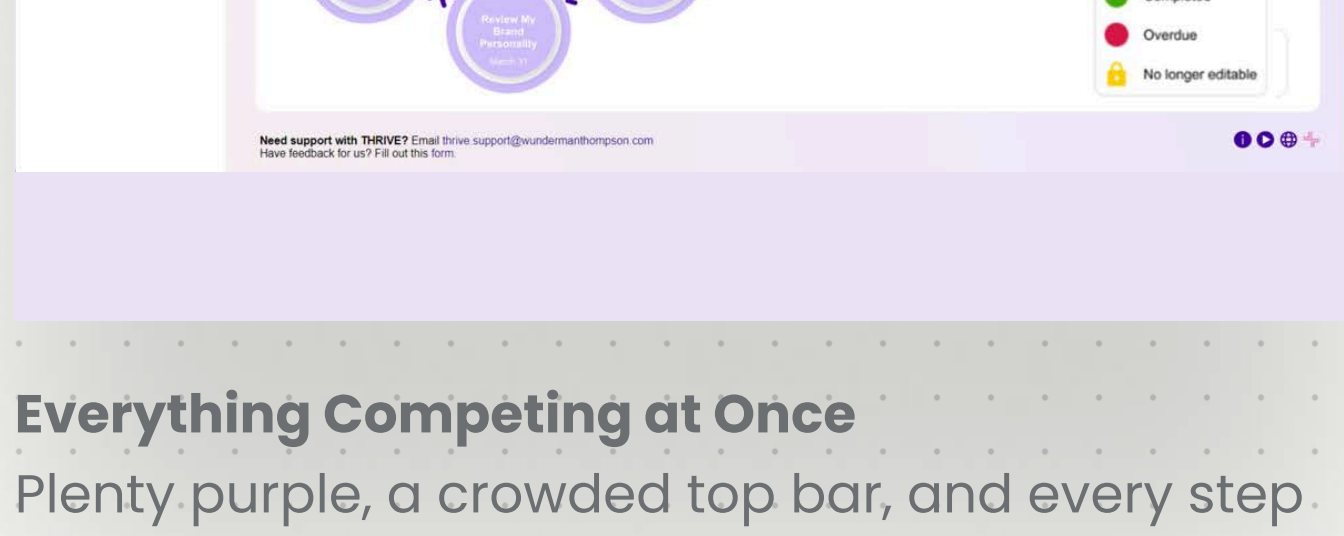
Key Stakeholders

- **Product Manager:** Global Director, Talent and Org Effectiveness
- **Brand Sign-Off:** Executive Director, Global Marcomms

Sneak Peek

Before

Original Thrive Home Screen

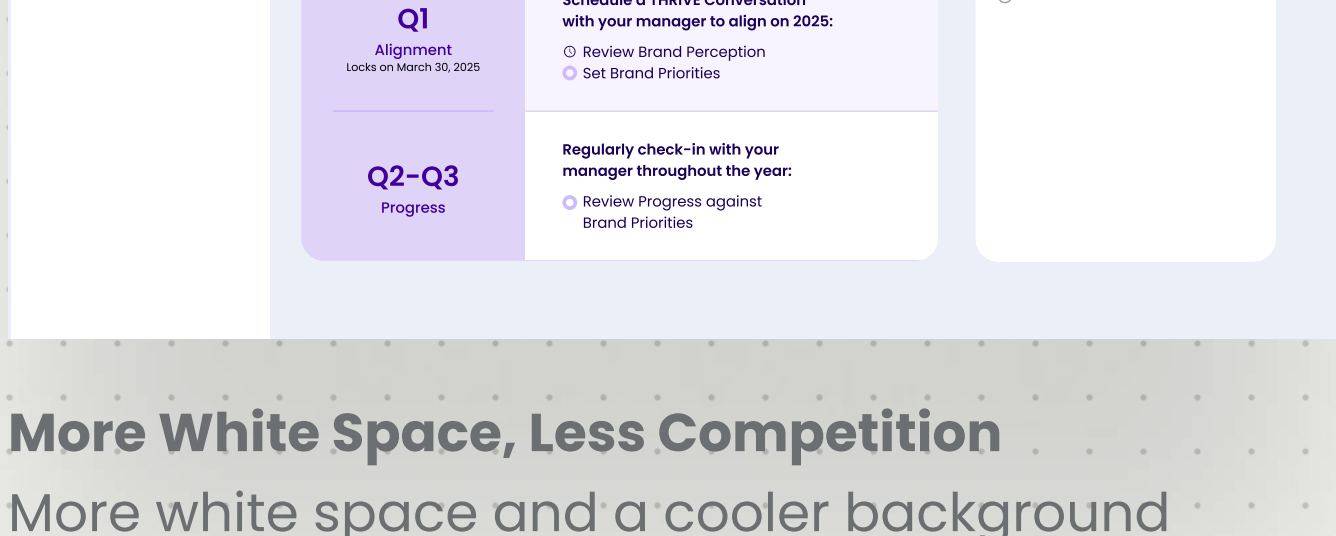


Everything Competing at Once

Plenty purple, a crowded top bar, and every step shown at once left little clear to focus on.

After

Redesigned Thrive Home Screen



More White Space, Less Competition

More white space and a cooler background sharpened the visual hierarchy so content could stand out, like the AI coach added to the hero display for easy access.

The Brand Had to Stand on Its Own

Thrive's original look belonged to a company that no longer existed. My PM's first idea was a three-way sub-brand system uniting VMLY&R's Drive Your Career, Wunderman Thompson's Authentic Personal Brand, and Thrive. I explored directions built on fingerprints for authenticity, vines for growth, and fragments of the VMLY&R snowflake. In the end, the Executive Director of Global Marcomms narrowed the work to one new VML-aligned palette, which set the direction for every screen.

THRIVE

4 Step Fix

Testing

What Users Told Us

I wrote the test plan and ran four 45-minute moderated sessions with my PM, serving as the primary note taker. The findings were consistent. People weren't sure where to start, and they could jump into any step regardless of what they'd completed. Some didn't recognize the onboarding videos as videos, clicking the language and download icons instead of play, because nothing on the card said 'watch this.'

User Testing Notes

A sample of rough user test observation notes

NAME	OBSERVATION
Zh Location: Ukraine, Account Manager Part Time: Asia East, South & Central EMEA	202 TEST 1 - Zh was excited bc she is interested in professional development for her career - Zh mentions we could use a better designed email template - She is "cautious" with email, that can look like spam "Especially from someone you don't know" - Zh carefully reads email - Email link may be broken over tenant issues. The link didn't successfully send her to the Thrive App DURING USER TEST - Loves the design, simple, not cluttered - I'm not sure where to navigate - What does "play" button stand for - Are these articles? (referring to videos) - Everything under "THRIVE" is too in focus, clear - While a mix of use. She says "I become... GOOD, clear" - While analyzing 1st screen, Zh scrolls to the bottom without mentioning to do list on left or icons at bottom - She notices locks on the cycle points (seems to understand their purpose) and she reads through - Zh goes to "2021 - 2024" at the top left and plays w filters and chips at top - She chose to go to "stage1" to begin - These cards look like they navigate to some articles, she clicks on video globe icon (Clicker On globe icon and downloads the transcript) - She sees that it's a guide in diff languages - I direct her back to top and she sees "start here" and confirms she's somewhere in the right spot - V.T. interacts as well to let her know to start w first video - Zh changes video to Zh speed - After video "After 1st video, Zh says, "Makes more sense" - V.T. directs Zh to watch all 3 of 1st videos - Zh notes that the buttons are more properly aligned in the video, it seems share screen has squashed her app and it is not the best responsive design - After watching video, Zh understands the assignment well - She goes to nominations and tests the limits of the search colleagues feature

Not sure where to navigate	What does the "My Self" button stand for?	Are these articles? (about the videos)
Overwhelmed by the first screen	Started on Priorities, instead of Nominations. The red bubble were misleading	Users can click any step, even without finishing the ones before it
"Makes more sense" (said after watching one video)	3 missed the notification about manager feedback	Scrolled right past "Start here"

Redesign Decisions

Fewer Buttons Made the Starting Point Clear

Testers didn't know where to start. I moved the view switcher into sidebar tabs and folded Resources, Help, and support contacts into one "?" icon.

A Moving Bell Made Reminders Hard to Miss

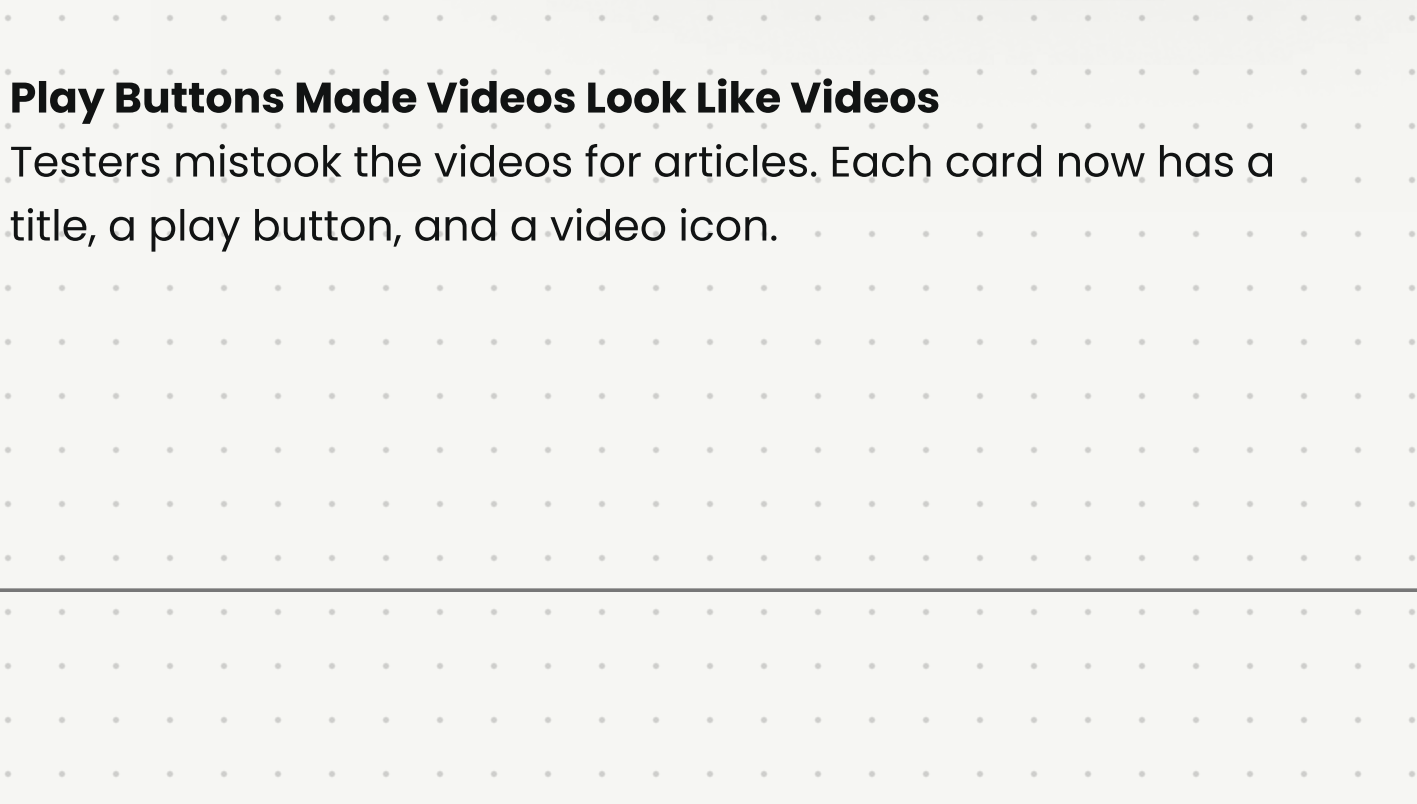
Testers missed key notifications, so I animated the bell to flag anything new.

Built for Return Visits

A Table Made Progress Trackable
A wheel explains a process but it was hard to track. A table shows returning users exactly where they left off laid out from left to right, top to bottom in natural reading order.

Locking Future Steps Kept Users on Track
Testers could click into any step, even ones they weren't ready for. Now only the current step is clickable, so users can't go the wrong way. (Highlighted in yellow)

Clearer Statues Showed What Needed Attention
Six statuses, a feedback request checklist, and each quarter's lock date put everything due in one view.



Play Buttons Made Videos Look Like Videos

Testers mistook the videos for articles. Each card now has a title, a play button, and a video icon.

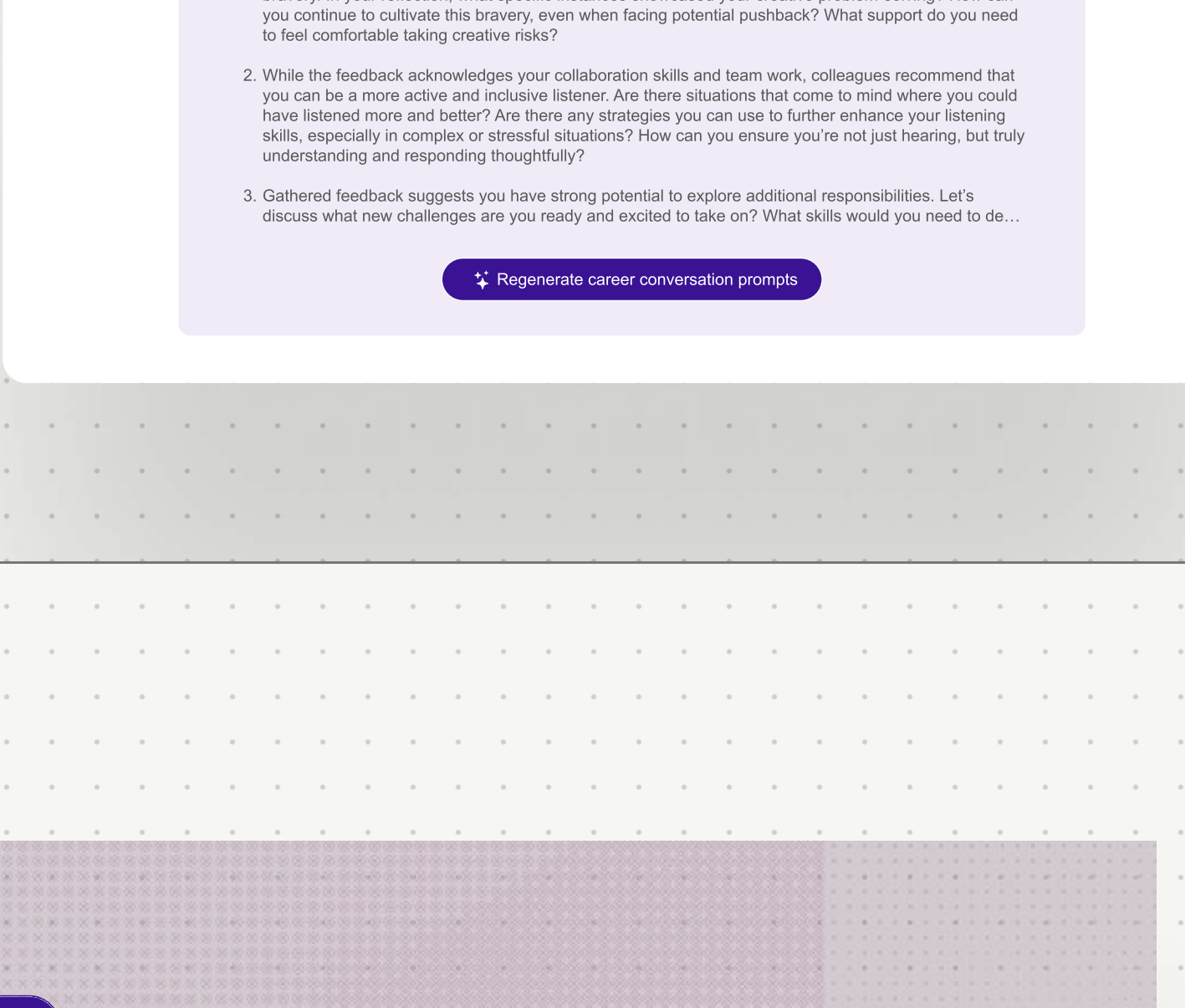
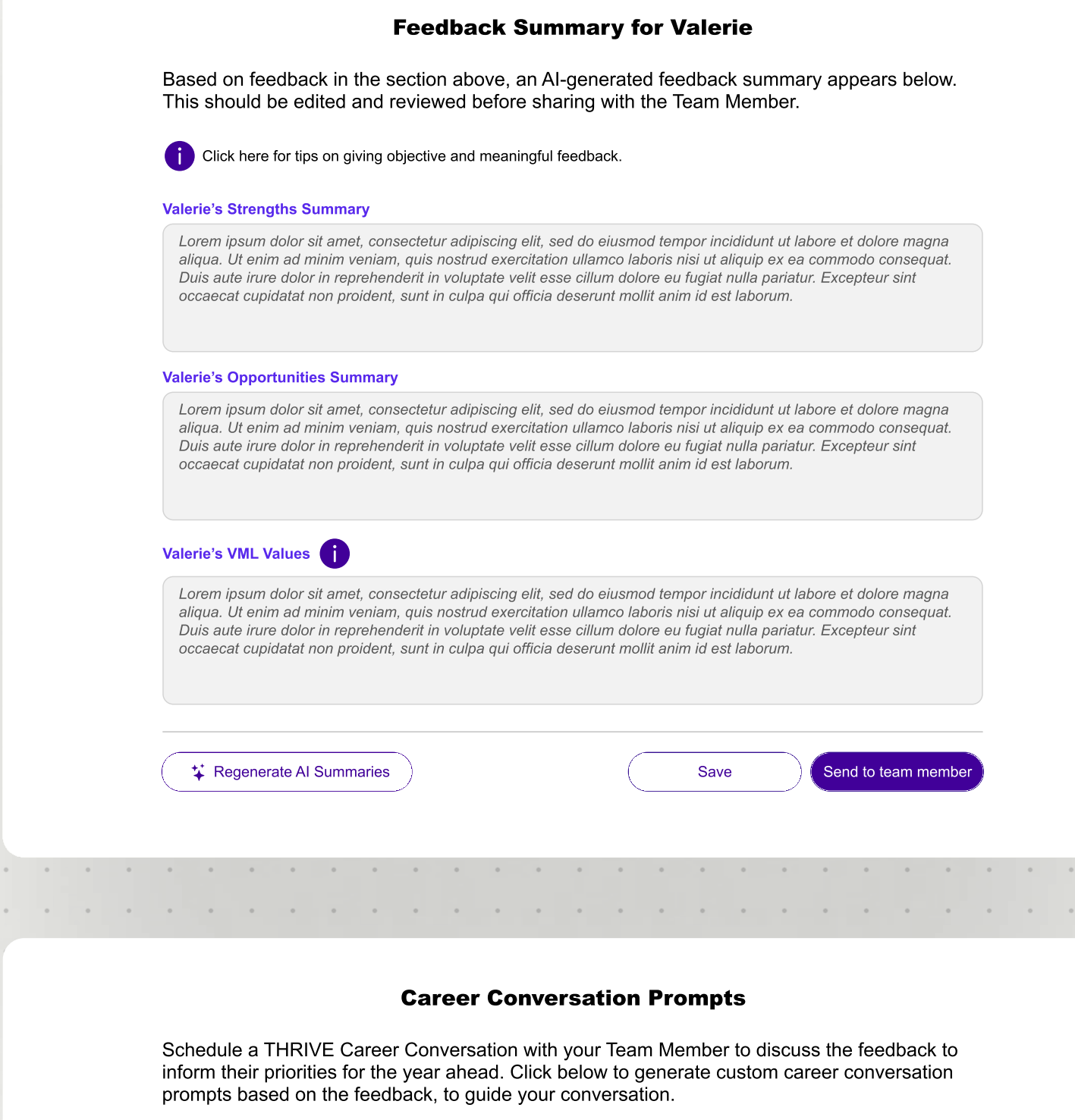
Confetti Confirmed the Finish Line

Testers missed the message telling them they were done, so a celebratory animation now makes the end of each cycle unmistakable.

Prototype

AI Summaries Managers Trusted

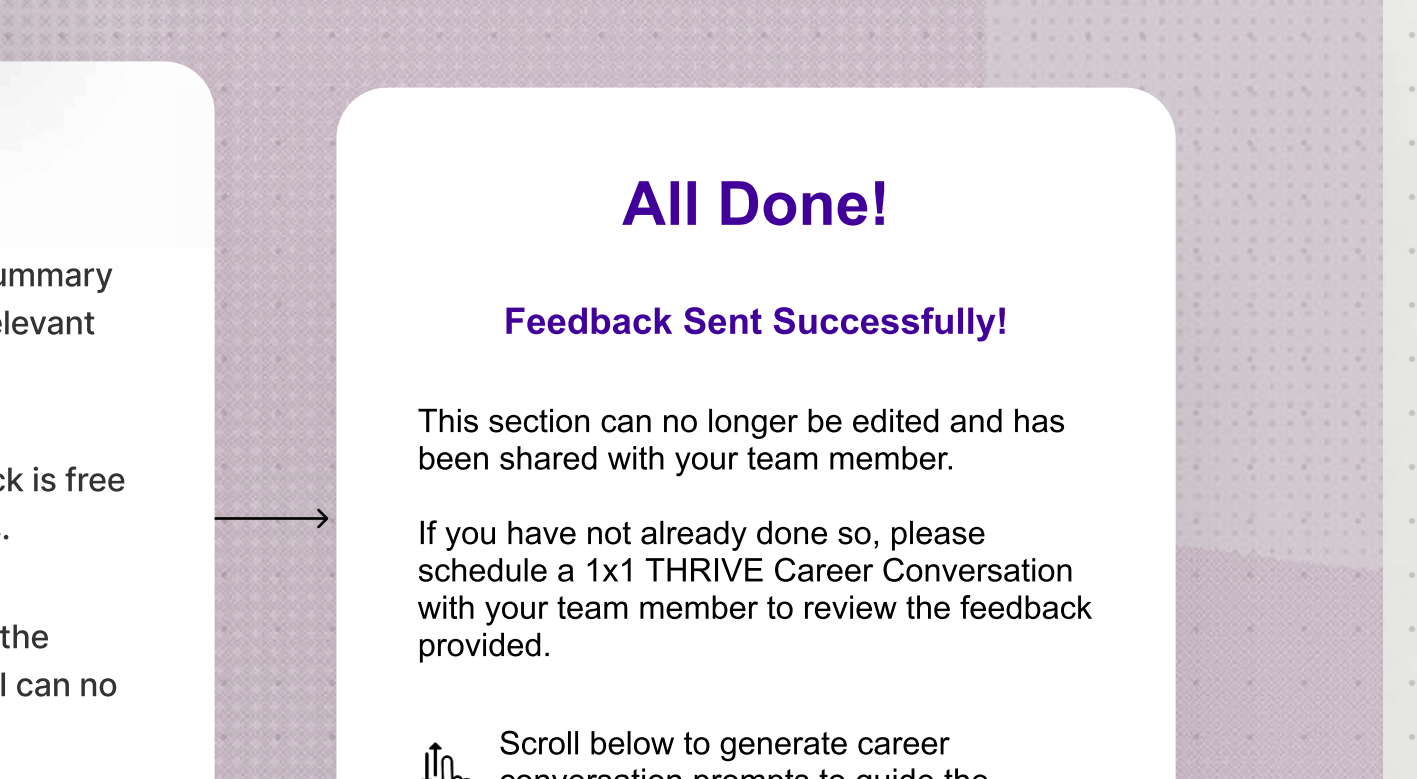
My PM explained the initial flows. I refined them and turned them into real Figma mockups across multiple rounds. Managers read every submission first, generating a summary was optional, and they could edit it before using it. Employees and managers both knew where AI was involved. This process saved managers time on reading and and manually combining and summarizing feedback from as many as 10 direct reports.



Onboarding

1 Video Led to 10 More

I produced the first onboarding video with on-screen callouts showing exactly where to look. A production team used it as the template for the remaining 10+ videos.



Results

Recognition

"Human-Assisted, Not Human-Replacing"

"A brilliant and practical use of AI. With 10 direct reports it's a time-saver... the perfect example of human-assisted not Human-replacing."

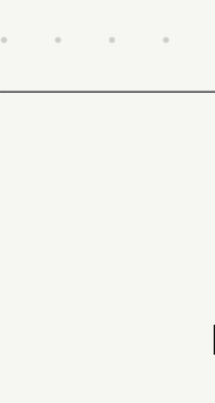
— Global Chief Strategy Officer



WorkLife Awards 2024
Most Dedicated to Employee Growth



Business Culture Awards 2024
Best Personal Development, Coaching & Mentoring Initiative



WorkLife Awards 2024
Best Use of AI in the Workplace for Thrive's AI coach and AI-generated feedback features.



Engage Awards 2024
Best Use of Technology to Drive Employee Engagement

Reflection

Confident, But Not Confirmed

What I'd Do Differently

I'd push for a quick validation round before launch. Development time was expensive, but testing a Figma prototype wasn't. Even two or three sessions would have confirmed the redesign fixed what the first four found. The feedback from managers suggests it did. I'd just rather have known before launch.